

Annual Report on the Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities *Year 5 (2014–2015)*

Executive Summary



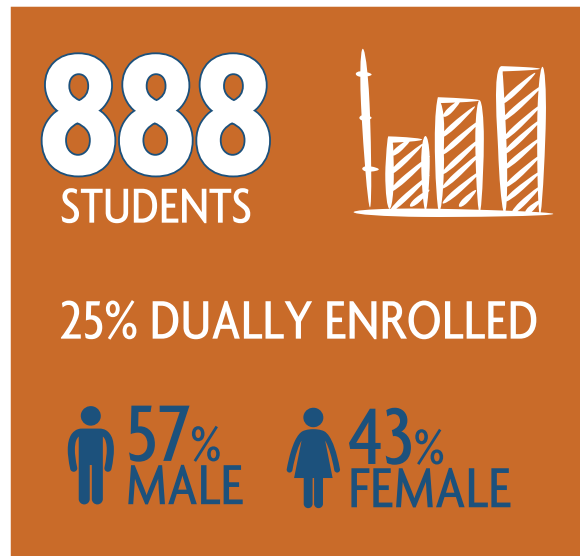
PRIMARY FINDINGS OF THE YEAR FIVE REPORT

DEMOGRAPHICS

The fifth year of the Transition Postsecondary Program for Students with Intellectual Disability (TPSID program) commenced on October 1, 2014. The TPSID program was comprised of 27 model demonstration projects being implemented on 52 college or university campuses. In 2014–2015, 16 programs operated on single college campuses, and 11 operated as consortia, with 36 satellite college campuses. Fourteen of these sites were located at two-year IHEs, and 38 sites were located at four-year IHEs.

During Year Five, 888 students attended the 52 TPSID programs, for an average of 17 students per site. As of September 2015, 18 TPSID sites had been approved as a Comprehensive Transition Program (CTP) and were able to offer eligible students access to certain forms of Title IV student aid. In the 2014–2015 school year, 423 TPSID students were newly enrolled, and 465 were continuing students.

In 2014–2015, 57% of TPSID students were male and 43% were female². Most students were white (73%), 15% were black or African American, and 11% were Hispanic or Latino. Over 90% of students were between the ages of 18 and 25, and 89% of enrolled students had an intellectual disability (ID) and/or autism. The remaining 11% of students were reported as having other disabilities. One quarter of students (25%) were dually enrolled, i.e., receiving special education transition services from a public school system while attending the TPSID program.



ACADEMIC ACCESS

Course enrollment information was reported for 784 of the 829 students who attended TPSID programs and for whom we had individual (as opposed to aggregate) data. 784 students enrolled in a total of 5,775 college or university courses. This is an average of seven courses per student per year³. Students at two-year IHEs took an average of seven courses, while those at four-year IHEs took an average of eight courses a year.

A majority of course enrollments (55%) were in courses designed for and delivered to only students with ID in the TPSID. The remaining 45% were in academically inclusive courses, i.e., typical college courses attended by students with ID and other college students. The percentage of enrollments in inclusive courses was higher at two-year IHEs than at four-year IHEs.

The most common accommodations were academic supports, such as note-takers and readers. Students also received enrollment accommodations, such as modified course loads, substitutes for



² Omits data reported at the aggregate level

³ Some students did not take any courses because they were in a stage of their program where the focus was not on academics, but rather on employment and career development. Therefore, course enrollment data were not reported for some students.

required courses, and priority registration, as well as academic accommodations, such as access to professors' notes, advance access to materials, and alternative test formats. A majority of students attending TPSIDs (75%) were seeking a credential in 2014–2015. A majority (89%) of TPSID programs used peer mentors to provide academic supports to students in the programs.

CAREER DEVELOPMENT AND EMPLOYMENT

Of the 888 students attending TPSID programs in 2014–2015, 345 (39%) held a total of 438 paid jobs⁴. Some students have held the same job for multiple years while also attending a TPSID program. One hundred twenty-eight jobs (29%) were jobs that students had held since Year Four, 28 were jobs students had held since Year Three, 9 were jobs they had held since Year Two, and 4 were jobs they had held since Year One.

Individual paid jobs accounted for 280 of the paid jobs held by students (64%), and paid internships (credit and non-credit) accounted for 28%. Seventy-seven percent of the paid jobs held by students paid at or above minimum wage. In addition to paid employment, over half of the enrolled students in Year Five (60%) participated in other career development activities to prepare for the workforce. The most common career development activities were volunteering and/or community service (30%) and service learning (19%).

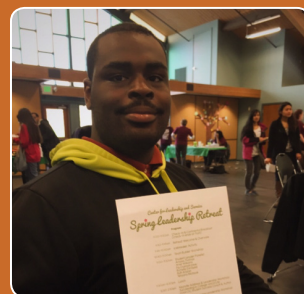
Length of student attendance impacted rates of employment: the longer students attended, the more likely they were to be employed. Challenges to engaging in paid employment included lack of preparation and career assessment prior to students entering their college program, as well as a lack of staff knowledge and training about state-of-the-art customized and integrated employment practices.

Students who attended more academically inclusive programs, i.e., programs where more than 50% of course enrollments across all students are in inclusive courses, were more likely to participate in both paid employment and other career development activities than students who attended programs that are less academically inclusive, i.e., those that primarily enroll students in specialized courses.

⁴ Omits data reported at the aggregate level

Evan's Story

Evan came to **ACHIEVE** at Highline College through his school district's transition program. Having spent two years in the transition program, he was ready to embrace the rigor and opportunity of college life.



One of Evan's first classes at Highline was Career Planning and Evaluation, a general college course full of students interested in exploring their skills and potential career pathways. Through the coursework, classroom discussion, and a variety of career assessments, Evan learned of his desire for a structured, steady, work environment and a chance to use his precise technical skills.

He then decided to take a Business Information Technology course, where he could work on expanding his computer skills. He also completed internships in two different areas: photo assistant and medical records administrative assistant.

Evan expanded his ability and comfort with communicating with a variety of groups by participating in a campus-based leadership seminar, and by joining the writing club, where he shared his passion for writing with other students. At the end of the year, he joined other student leaders in a spring retreat to celebrate accomplishments and plan for the future.

Evan's future seemed like it couldn't get any brighter when, just after graduation, he was offered a job at the City of Seattle as an office assistant, working over 20 hours per week with benefits. This is only the beginning for Evan, and Highline is proud to have been part of his journey!

SELF-DETERMINATION

In Year Five of the program, person-centered planning was used in 96% of TPSIDs. Students sought academic advising from existing academic advising offices in 50% of TPSIDs, and 50% used only a separate advising system specially designed for students who attend the TPSID.

Common motivations for students to enroll in coursework were that the course was required for the TPSID credential (59% of course enrollments), was required for a degree or certificate (58%), matched the student's personal interests (49%), or related to their career goals (43%). Year Five saw a slight increase in students taking courses because they were related to their career goals (43% of enrollments) when compared to Year Four (35%), despite decreases in previous academic years. The majority of TPSIDs offered students' families information about IHE-related issues such as social activities (92%), Institution of Higher Education (IHE) code of conduct (77%), disability-related services available at the IHE (71%), the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) (71%), non-disability-related services (60%), and financial aid (54%).

CAMPUS MEMBERSHIP

In 2014–2015, every TPSID reported facilitating or supporting student participation in campus social activities, including attending events on campus, going out with friends, and attending or participating in sporting events. Some students participated independently; others received support from TPSID staff or peer mentors. A small minority (4%) of students was reported as not participating in any social activities.

In Year Five, 44% of TPSIDs were commuter schools that did not provide housing for any students. Of those TPSIDs located at IHEs that did offer housing, 14 provided students in the TPSID access to that housing, and 15 did not. Of the 224 students living in TPSID or IHE housing, 60% lived in an on-campus or off-campus setting where the majority of the students are TPSID students. Nearly two thirds of those living off-campus, but not with their families, lived independently (63%), with another 14% in supervised or supported living settings. Students who lived in TPSID or IHE housing generally had higher levels of participation in social activities.

EXITING STUDENTS

A total of 324 students exited their TPSID program in Year Five. Overall, 40% of students who exited had a paid job when they exited their program. The most common reason for exit was having completed the program and earned a credential (68%).

Overall, 80% of the students who exited earned one or more credentials before exiting. This is the highest percentage of credential earners thus far in the TPSID funding period. Students who exited programs at four-year IHEs were slightly more likely to have earned a credential than students who exited programs at two-year IHEs (91% versus 66%). A certificate specifically for students in the TPSID program granted by the IHE was the most common credential at both two-year and four-year IHEs.

Three quarters of students who exited in Year Five (76%) were reported as having a paid job, participating in unpaid career development activities, or doing both at the time they exited. At exit, 110 students were working in a paid job and 193 participated in some sort of unpaid career development activities. Seventy-two students were both employed for pay

and participating in unpaid career development activities when they exited their program. Students who were dually enrolled in high school and college in their final year were more likely to exit their program with a paid job than students who were enrolled as an adult student.

40% of students who exited had a paid job when they exited their program.

EVALUATION

Each TPSID, in addition to using the National Coordinating Center (NCC) evaluation system, created its own mechanisms for self-assessment. The evaluation tools used by TPSIDs included assessment of students' academic and career interests and progress, goal attainment, and self-determination. TPSIDs regularly sought feedback from students, faculty, peer mentors, family members, TPSID staff, and employers of students via interviews and meetings. Sixty-two percent of TPSIDs also collected follow-up data on students who exited the program, reflecting a steady increase over time starting with 23% in Year One.

ALIGNMENT WITH COLLEGE SYSTEMS AND PRACTICES

In Year Five, TPSID programs followed the academic calendar used by the IHE at 94% of the reporting TPSIDs (N=52). The overwhelming majority (89%) indicated that they held students to the IHE's code of conduct, and 98% issued students college or university ID cards. Eighty-one percent issued students a transcript, and well over half of the programs issued regular transcripts.

Forty percent of TPSIDs stated that students accessed all campus resources that were listed as options in the evaluation system. The most commonly accessed resources were the student center, dining hall, computer lab or IT services, bookstore, and library. The percentage of campuses at which students use career and tutoring services grew consistently from Years One through Three. The use of tutoring services stabilized at around 60% in Year Four and remained at 60% in Year Five. Use of career services peaked at 65% in Year Four and dipped to 56% in Year Five.

COORDINATION AND COLLABORATION

The 52 participating TPSIDs partnered with 237 external organizations. The most common external partnerships in Year Five were with vocational rehabilitation (VR) agencies, local education agencies (LEAs), employers, University Centers for Excellence in Developmental Disabilities (UCEDDs), and employers. VR agencies were the most frequent external partnership to be reported for the second consecutive year in Year Five. VR agencies were the most frequent partnership in Year Two as well, and partnerships with LEAs were most common in Years One and Three.

The three most common partner roles were providing services directly to students, serving as a consultant, and participating in a project advisory committee. The percentage of TPSIDs partnering with employers decreased slightly between Years Four and Five, from 45% to 40%. However, partnerships with employers increased each year from Years One through Four. Staff from 79% of TPSIDs participated in professional development provided by their IHE, and 83% had staff that participated in professional development provided by an entity external to the IHE.

SUSTAINABILITY

In Year Five, 90% of TPSIDs received financial support from external sources, such as state VR agencies and state intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) services agencies. In 18 of the 40 instances where VR agencies partnered with TPSID programs, the agency provided funds for student tuition. For tuition and non-tuition expenses, private pay (i.e., personal funds) was the option most commonly used. Tuition was waived for various reasons for 15% of students. Seventeen TPSID sites were approved CTPs, and could offer eligible students access to certain forms of federal student aid. Pell Grants were the most common form of federal student aid. Annual costs of the TPSID programs varied widely, ranging from no cost at all to \$42,000, and depended upon the type of institution (two-year or four-year) and whether the IHE charges were residency-dependent, e.g., in-state, out-of-state, city resident, etc.

CONCLUSION

Over the past five years, the TPSID program established unprecedented infrastructure at 57 colleges and universities, built capacity in their policies and staffing, and established access to higher learning experiences for thousands of youth with intellectual disability (ID). The fifth and final year of the 2010–2015 funded TPSID programs reflected growth in many critical areas.

Employment rates, both while students were enrolled in the program (39%) and 90 days after they exited (40%), reflected increases from the previous year, and demonstrated that students with ID can attend college and engage in paid employment simultaneously. Students with ID were active members of the student community, with 71% of enrolled students participating in formal campus-wide social events (e.g., sporting events, clubs or student organizations, fraternities/sororities). TPSID students also engaged in informal social activities, such as hanging out with personal friends or going to listen to music on and off campus (65%). Most often, peer mentors supported students' participation in social events.

Year Five also brought the highest percentage of students who earned a credential at exit (80%). These credentials varied in their format and structure and the extent to which they reflected standard IHE practices. However, in many cases they represented the first credential available at these IHEs to this traditionally marginalized group of learners.

Inclusive course access was established or broadened in most of the colleges and universities hosting a TPSID program. Over 10,000 inclusive courses were attended by students enrolled in TPSID programs over the five years of the project, and 76% of these courses were taken for some type of credit. This finding demonstrates that students with ID, when given the expectation, opportunity, and needed supports and accommodations, CAN access college-level coursework, and, if desired, CAN earn college credits.

The breadth of course subjects also reflects significant progress. Students attending the TPSID programs in Year Five enrolled in a diverse array of coursework addressing many academic domains including history (e.g. 19th Century History, Games in Medieval Europe), science (e.g. Anatomy and Physiology, Animal Biology, Dairy Evaluation) technology (Media in the Digital Age, Fundamentals of Business Communication) and literature (Gender in Children's Literature, Literature and the Bible). The diversity of the academic topics as well as the range of instructional levels reflects that students attending TPSID programs were offered the opportunity to access coursework that fell well outside of what historically has been seen as curriculum "needed" by students with ID.

As reflected in this and previous annual reports, students attending TPSID programs also engaged in a wide array of career development and employment activities, and the employment and career development data over time shows some promising trends. Both the percentage of students working in at least one paid job and the percentage of students participating in other career development activities have increased since the TPSID program began. Participation in paid employment has increased from 30% in Year One to 39% in Year Five, while participation in other career development activities increased from 52% to 60% over the same period. The extent to which students engaged in and maintained integrated paid employment was largely determined by the manner in which the TPSID grant approached the domain of employment.

As these data emerge, we are beginning to see a connection between the level of academic inclusion and student career development and employment experiences. Students enrolled in more academically inclusive programs were more likely to

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participate in both paid employment and other career development activities than students who attended programs that were less academically inclusive. Fifty-two percent of students at more inclusive programs had a paid job in Year Five, compared to just 20% of students at less inclusive programs.

The TPSID model demonstration program has created access and services in higher education for students with ID, who have been previously excluded from these learning environments. It has also created the opportunity to gather the first, and perhaps only, longitudinal dataset around higher education access for this population of students. These data serve as a proof of concept that students with ID can engage in and benefit from higher learning, and that colleges and universities can be responsive to the diverse learning needs of people with ID and successfully integrate them into these learning communities.

It is affirming that as grant funding fades, the majority of the IHEs that received these funds plan to continue to serve students with ID in the future. In many states, the existence of the TPSID projects has also led to increased awareness and support for expansion of access to other colleges and universities not involved with the TPSID program. In some cases, this momentum has resulted in expanded state policies or the allocation of new state funding for inclusive higher education for students with ID, as has occurred in Colorado, Florida, North Carolina, South Carolina, Massachusetts, Tennessee, and Texas. This positive snowball effect will result in greater development and expansion of higher education options, and increased numbers of students with ID who have the chance to determine how a path to and through higher education can lead to a better life.

Students enrolled in more academically inclusive programs were more likely to participate in both paid employment and other career development activities than students who attended programs that were less academically inclusive.

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RECOMMENDED CITATION

Grigal, M., Hart, D., Smith, F. A., Domin, D., Sulewski, J., Weir, C. (2016). *Think College National Coordinating Center: Annual report on the transition and postsecondary programs for students with intellectual disabilities (2014–2015)—Executive Summary*. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.

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